SPIRITUAL REALITY · HEART OF WORSHIP ·
JOHN 3:16 · OPEN · PORN AGAIN? · FUELED

SPRING 2027

Group Leader Content · Southeast Students

2026–2027

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SECTION 00

START UP

EVERYTHING TO KNOW BEFORE YOU LEAD A GROUP

IN THIS SECTION

START UP

Before the first group meets, walk through these four essentials. They set the rhythm, keep students safe, and define the kind of leader we're committing to be.

01 **USING THIS GUIDE** — 1
HOW TO LEAD A WEEK

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WHO & WHAT WE COMMIT TO

FOR SMALL-GROUP LEADERS

USING THIS GUIDE

Every week follows the same rhythm. The left page is your **prep**—know it before group. The right page is your **discussion**—use it to guide discussion.

PASSAGE	The week's Scripture. Read it together before you dig in.
KEY TAKEAWAY	The one idea students should leave with. Aim everything here.
CALL TO ACTION	The response you're guiding them toward this week.
QUESTIONS	**Personal** warms them up. **Biblical** digs into the text. **Applicable** brings it home.
PRAYER PROMPT	Pray it as written, or put it in your own words.
PERSONAL CHALLENGE	A step for students to carry through the week.

01 Facilitate, don't teach. Use more question marks than periods, leave room for silence, and follow up with your students through the week. #leadertip

GUARDRAILS

STOPLIGHT GUIDE

SCAN FOR THE FULL COURSE



SE Students wants every leader to promote safety and awareness in tough conversations. Ministry is messy and these topics can feel intimidating—here are the **guidelines for how to best proceed**.

GREEN LIGHT

"Green means go."

You've got this. You have both the Sword and the Spirit.

- Family problems
- Relational problems
- Homesickness
- Heartfelt confessions
- Questions about dating & sex
- Church & theological questions

YELLOW LIGHT

"Proceed with caution."

Mention it to a staff member for coaching.

- Bullying
- Pornography
- Eating disorders
- Drugs or alcohol
- Anxiety or depression
- Engagement in sexual activity
- Gender & sexual identity questions

RED LIGHT

"Stop and get help."

Get a staff member and bring them into the conversation.

- Self-injury
- Hearing voices / hallucinations
- Sexual & physical abuse reported
- Suicidal / homicidal thoughts (threats to harm)

STUDENT TO LEADER: IN PERSON

Southeast takes seriously the responsibility of keeping our people safe. Here are some best practices when interacting with students in person.

PROGRAMMING

- **Keep students in programming.** We want all students in the student room. If a student wants to talk one-on-one, wait until after program and groups end, and meet in a public area where you are visible to others.
- **Appropriate interactions.** Appropriate touches with a student: handshakes, high-fives, and side hugs.
- **When a student's ride is late.** Never leave a student waiting alone—wait with two adults. If you have a parent or guardian's permission to drive a student home, bring another cleared adult.

COUNSELING

- **Counsel same gender.** If a student of the opposite gender comes to you for counsel, connect them with a leader of the same gender.
- **Be visible.** Meet in a public area where you are visible to other people. Never meet in private.
- **Review the Counseling Spotlight.** When counseling a student, refer to the **Stoplight Guide** on how to best proceed in conversation.

OUTSIDE OF CHURCH

- **Pair up with another leader.** When planning an outside activity with students, always include another cleared adult and stay within the 1:25 student/leader ratio.
- **Transporting students.** Never give a student a ride home unless you have another cleared leader in the vehicle and a parent's or guardian's approval.
- **Communicating digitally.** When texting or using social media with students, follow the **Digital Communication Safety Guardrails** on the next page.

STUDENT TO LEADER: ONLINE

When it comes to digital interactions, the following are some best practices to promote safety and create a healthy environment between leaders and students.

TALK TO PARENTS FIRST

Make parents and guardians fully aware of all the digital methods that will be used to communicate with students for ministry purposes.

KEEP IT PLURAL

Want to let an absent student know they were missed, or tell someone you're proud of them? Use plural pronouns instead of singular ones. Rather than "I missed you," say "We missed you."

ADD A CO-LEADER

Adding another leader helps with accountability. Group texting is the preference for all digital communication. At no time should one-on-one video communication take place between a student and leader.

COMMUNICATION LIMITS

Most conversations can wait until the next day—a healthy boundary. Use "scheduled sending" for messages composed outside acceptable hours (e.g. write a message at 9:30 p.m. and schedule it to go out at 7:00 a.m. the next day).

TRACEABLE COMMUNICATION

Apps with a "self-destruct mode" can create dangers when adults use them to communicate with minors. To be above reproach, only communicate with students in ways that are traceable. Never delete a conversation with a student.

HIGH CALLING

LEADER COMMITMENT

Serving with minors is a trusted leadership role. The following commitments define **who we commit to be** and **what we commit to do** so students are discipled, cared for, and protected with integrity.

WHAT WE COMMIT TO BE

01	**Christ Follower**	I acknowledge Jesus Christ as Lord and will keep growing through the Bible, prayer, worship, and community in the life of the church.
02	**Representative**	I represent Jesus, Southeast Christian Church, Southeast Students and will support the church's mission, beliefs, leadership, and unity.
03	**Above Reproach**	I will live with integrity in my words, actions, relationships, habits, and online presence, and will not knowingly misrepresent Jesus or Southeast.
04	**Trustworthy**	I will use my influence to protect, encourage, and disciple students—never to manipulate, isolate, shame, favor, or create inappropriate dependence.
05	**Teachable**	I will receive coaching, correction, and direction with humility. Teachability is part of faithful leadership.
06	**Disciple-Maker**	This is more than a weekly program. I will pray for students, help them feel known, and point them to Jesus and their next steps of faith.
07	**Integrity**	If my ability to lead with integrity becomes compromised, I will speak with Staff and, if needed, step back from serving.
08	**Conflict Resolution**	Following Matthew 18:15-17, I will handle conflict with humility—going directly to the person, avoiding gossip, pursuing reconciliation, and involving the right leaders when needed.

WHAT WE COMMIT TO DO

01	**Serve Faithfully**	I will serve the full ministry year—August through July—and participate in weekly gatherings, leader trainings, and all required ministry rhythms.
02	**Consistent**	I will be on time, prepared, and engaged when serving. Consistency builds trust with students, families, leaders, and staff.
03	**Communicate**	If I need to miss a gathering, event, or serving commitment, I will tell my co-leaders and Staff as early as possible.
04	**Be a Teammate**	I will work with co-leaders, campus staff, parents, and SE Students leadership in a way that is clear, cooperative, and aligned.
05	**Safety Guidelines**	I will follow all Southeast and Southeast Students safety policies and boundaries at all times, including:

- Never being alone with a student in a private or isolated setting.
- Appropriate physical, emotional, spiritual, relational, and digital boundaries.
- Communicating with students only in transparent and approved ways.
- Reporting concerns, disclosures, or unsafe situations to Staff immediately.

AGREEMENT

By signing, I confirm I have read, understand, and agree to these commitments as a leader with Southeast Students. Failure to follow these commitments may result in being paused or removed from serving. If I have questions or cannot agree to any commitment, I will speak with Staff before serving.

PRINT NAME _____ LEADER SIGNATURE _____ DATE _____

SERIES ONE

SPIRITUAL REALITY

HOW DO YOU SEE THE WORLD? · 2 WEEKS · MSM + HSM

SERIES DATES

SERIES OVERVIEW

SPIRITUAL REALITY

How do you see the world? What's the point of following Jesus? What does God actually want from us? In a world full of competing voices, rules, and expectations, it's easy to lose sight of what matters most. In this series, students will explore the spiritual reality we find when we open God's Word. Just like VR changes what you see and experience, the Bible helps us see God's reality. And in the Bible, we see a call to believe in Jesus and love others as He commanded. Through reading the letters John wrote, we'll discover that following Jesus isn't just about knowing the right answers or following a list of rules—it's about knowing God, walking as Jesus walked, and allowing His love to change the way we treat others.

Series anchor text: 1 John 3:23

Series goal: Students will understand the spiritual reality that following Jesus means loving Him and loving others.

SERIES OUTLINE

MSM · WEEK 1	**Love God**	1 John 2:3-6
MSM · WEEK 2	**Love Others**	1 John 4:7-12
HSM · WEEK 1	**1 John**	1 John
HSM · WEEK 2	**2 & 3 John**	2 John; 3 John

02

Follow up during the week. Students need someone to walk with them, not talk at them—a relationship carried past group can change a life. #leadertip

01 SPIRITUAL REALITY · MSM
LOVE GOD

PASSAGE **1 John 2:3-6**

KEY TAKEAWAY

The spiritual reality is that following Jesus starts with knowing God and walking as Jesus walked.

CALL TO ACTION

Choose to show God that you love and trust Him this week through one simple act of obedience.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Who is someone you know really well? How did you get to know them?
2. Have you ever said you cared about something or someone, but your actions didn't really show it? What happened?

BIBLICAL

1. Read 1 John 2:3-6.
   - What words, ideas, or phrases stick out to you from these verses?
   - What questions do you have about these verses?
2. Reread verses 3-4. John connects knowing God with obeying His commands. Why do you think obedience is connected to knowing God?
3. Reread verses 5-6. John says that "whoever claims to live in Jesus should walk as Jesus did." What do you think it means to walk as Jesus walked? What might that look like in everyday life?

APPLICABLE

1. What is one area of your life where it's difficult for you to obey Jesus?
2. What's one thing you could do this week to walk more like Jesus at home, at school, or with your friends?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, thank You for loving me and allowing me to know You. Help me not just to say I follow You, but to live like Jesus. Show me where I need to obey You and give me the courage to follow You."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Each day this week, ask yourself, "What is one way I can walk like Jesus today?" Choose one specific action and follow through on it.

02 SPIRITUAL REALITY · MSM
LOVE OTHERS

PASSAGE **1 John 4:7-12**

KEY TAKEAWAY

God first loved us, therefore we are called to love others.

CALL TO ACTION

Choose one person this week and intentionally show them the kind of love God has shown you.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Who is someone who makes you feel genuinely loved? What do they do that makes you feel that way?
2. What kind of people do you get along with easily? Why is it easy to love certain people?

BIBLICAL

1. Read 1 John 4:7-12.
   - What words, ideas, or phrases stick out to you from these verses?
   - What questions do you have about these verses?
2. Reread verses 7-8. Why do you think our relationship with God should affect the way we treat people?
3. Reread verses 11-12. Why do you think loving others is such an important part of following Jesus?

APPLICABLE

1. Who is someone in your life who might need to feel the love of God? What makes you think that?
2. What is one practical way you could show that person the love of Jesus this week?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, thank You for loving me first. Help me understand Your love more deeply so I can share it with others. Give me eyes to see people who need love and the courage to love them the way You have loved me."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Pray for the person you think needs some love each day this week. Take at least one practical step to show them love without expecting anything in return.

01 SPIRITUAL REALITY · HSM
1 JOHN

PASSAGE **1 John**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Reading God's Word in context helps us see the spiritual reality of what God is saying and how He calls us to live.

CALL TO ACTION

Make time to read Scripture beyond a few verses and discover how the whole message shapes your understanding of God.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Have you ever misunderstood something because you only heard part of the story? What happened?
2. When you read the Bible, do you usually read a few verses, a chapter, or more at a time? Why?

BIBLICAL

1. Read the entire book of 1 John.
   - What words, ideas, or phrases stick out to you from this book?
   - What questions do you have about what you read?
2. What themes or ideas did you notice repeated throughout the book? Why do you think John keeps coming back to them?
3. Throughout 1 John, John connects believing in Jesus, obeying God, and loving others. How do these three things relate to one another?

APPLICABLE

1. Can someone claim to follow Jesus while completely ignoring the way they live or treat others?
2. Which theme from 1 John challenged you the most: believing in Jesus, obeying God, loving others, or something else? Why?
3. How was reading the entire book different from reading a few verses at a time? Did seeing the whole message help you understand anything differently?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, thank You for giving us Your Word. Help me slow down and understand what I'm reading instead of just rushing through it. Give me wisdom to see the bigger picture, understand what You are teaching me, and live it out."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Choose another book of the Bible and read it in one sitting this week. As you read, pay attention to repeated words, major themes, and what the author wants you to understand. Write down three things you noticed.

02

SPIRITUAL REALITY · HSM

2 & 3 JOHN

PASSAGE **2 John; 3 John**

KEY TAKEAWAY

God calls us to walk in truth and love, using His Word as spiritual reality to shape what we believe and how we live.

CALL TO ACTION

Read Scripture with the goal of understanding it, then put its truth into practice in the way you live and treat others.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Have you ever had to decide whether to believe something you heard? How did you figure out if you should believe it or not?
2. Have you ever found it difficult to stand by what you believe because of what other people thought? What made it difficult?

BIBLICAL

1. Read the entire books of 2 John and 3 John.
   - What words, ideas, or phrases stick out to you from these books?
   - What questions do you have about what you read?
2. Both letters emphasize truth and love. Reread 2 John 4-6. How does John connect walking in truth with loving one another? Why do you think Christians need both truth and love?
3. Reread 2 John 7-11. Why is it important to know what God's Word teaches rather than simply believing everything we hear?

APPLICABLE

1. Where do you need to grow in living out God's truth, showing love to others, or discerning what you believe?
2. What's one way you can use God's Word to guide a decision, relationship, or conversation you have this week?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, thank You for giving me truth in Your Word. Help me recognize what is true, walk in Your ways, and love people well. Give me wisdom to know what to believe and courage to live out what You teach me."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Read another short book of the Bible in one sitting this week. Before you begin, ask God to help you understand His Word. After reading, write down the main message of the book, one thing you learned about God, and one way you can respond.

SERIES TWO

HEART OF WORSHIP

THIS IS YOUR SPIRITUAL ACT OF WORSHIP · 6 WEEKS

SERIES DATES _____

SERIES OVERVIEW

HEART OF WORSHIP

[TBD]

SERIES OUTLINE

WEEK 1	**[TBD]**	Revelation 2:1-7; Mark 12:28-34
WEEK 2	**[TBD]**	Revelation 4:1-11; Isaiah 6:1-8
WEEK 3	**[TBD]**	Revelation 5:1-10; 1 Peter 1:18-21
WEEK 4	**[TBD]**	Revelation 7:9-17; Ephesians 2:11-22
WEEK 5	**[TBD]**	Revelation 13:1-18; Daniel 3:13-18
WEEK 6	**[TBD]**	Revelation 22:7-21; Titus 2:11-14

03 Don't read off the curriculum. Know the passage ahead of time and ask in your own words; the less you look down, the more it feels like a real conversation. #leadertip

01 HEART OF WORSHIP
[TBD]

PASSAGE **Revelation 2:1-7; Mark 12:28-34**

KEY TAKEAWAY

A heart of worship begins with loving Jesus.

CALL TO ACTION

[TBD]

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. If time spent doing something showed your love, what would the world see you love in the way you spent your time this past week?
2. Have you ever had a season where you were busy doing something but realized your heart wasn't really in it?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Revelation 2:1-7.
   - What words or phrases stand out to you? What questions do you have about this passage?
   - What does Jesus compliment in this passage? Why is the church abandoning their first love such a serious issue?
2. What does Jesus instruct the church to do in verse 5, and how do remembering, repenting, and returning work together?
   - How does Jesus' teaching in Mark 12:28-34 help explain the relationship between love for God and love for others?

APPLICABLE

1. Where might you be going through the motions with God, and what would it look like to be honest with Him about that?
2. What would be one thing that you can do to live a life of loving worship?

PRAYER PROMPT

"Ask God to reveal where your love has grown cold. Thank Him for calling you back, and ask Him to help you love Him with your whole heart and extend that love to others."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Set aside ten minutes on three days this week to spend with Jesus. Read the week's passages, talk honestly with Him, and choose one intentional action that expresses love for someone else.

02 HEART OF WORSHIP
[TBD]

PASSAGE **Revelation 4:1-11; Isaiah 6:1-8**

KEY TAKEAWAY

A heart of worship recognizes God's greatness and surrenders to His authority.

CALL TO ACTION

[TBD]

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Where are you struggling to trust God's authority over your life?
2. Have you become so familiar with talking about God that you have stopped being amazed by Him?
3. What achievement, position of authority, or desire are you reluctant to surrender before the throne?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Revelation 4:1-11. What do the throne, the declarations of worship, and the elders' actions reveal about God?
2. How does Isaiah respond to God's holiness in Isaiah 6:1-8, and how does God address his sin?
3. How do the elders laying down their crowns and Isaiah offering himself for service illustrate responses to God's greatness?

APPLICABLE

1. What most often controls your choices: God's direction, your feelings, other people's opinions, or your desire to stay in control?
2. What is one area you need to surrender to God, and what would that surrender look like this week?

PRAYER PROMPT

"Praise God for His holiness and authority. Confess where you have resisted Him and thank Him for His grace."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Identify one decision where you have been resisting God's direction. Take one concrete step of obedience this week and share it with a trusted leader or friend.

03 HEART OF WORSHIP
[TBD]

PASSAGE **Revelation 5:1-10; 1 Peter 1:18-21**

KEY TAKEAWAY

A heart of worship responds with gratitude to Jesus, who gave His life to bring us to God.

CALL TO ACTION

[TBD]

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Has the sacrifice of Jesus become familiar information to you, or does it still move you toward gratitude?
2. Where are you trying to earn the love Jesus has already demonstrated?
3. How does belonging to Jesus shape your sense of identity and purpose?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Revelation 5:1-10. Why does John weep, and what makes Jesus uniquely worthy to open the scroll?
2. According to Revelation 5:9-10, what has Jesus accomplished through His death, and what has He made His people to be?
3. How does 1 Peter 1:18-21 deepen our understanding of the Lamb's sacrifice, redemption, and the hope we have in God?

APPLICABLE

1. How could remembering what Jesus has done change the way you approach worship when you feel distracted or uninterested?
2. If you belong to Jesus because He redeemed you, what difference should that make in how you live at school or at home?

PRAYER PROMPT

"Thank Jesus specifically for His sacrifice, forgiveness, and the gift of belonging to Him."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Read Revelation 5:9-10 each day this week. Each time, name one reason you are grateful to Jesus and choose a practical response by obedience, generosity, or service.

04 HEART OF WORSHIP
[TBD]

PASSAGE **Revelation 7:9-17; Ephesians 2:11-22**

KEY TAKEAWAY

A heart of worship celebrates belonging to God's people, united around the salvation He gives.

CALL TO ACTION

[TBD]

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Do you tend to evaluate worship primarily by whether it fits your preferences?
2. Who do you easily overlook or struggle to welcome into our church?
3. How has someone with a different background or experience helped you understand God more deeply?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Revelation 7:9-17. What does the multitude's diversity and shared worship reveal about the people God gathers?
2. How does God's care in Revelation 7:15-17 answer the suffering these people have experienced?
3. According to Ephesians 2:11-22, how does Jesus bring divided people together, and what new identity do they share?

APPLICABLE

1. How could you help build unity in our student ministry with people whose backgrounds, personalities, or preferences differ from yours?
2. Who needs to experience belonging, and what could you do to help them feel welcomed and valued?

PRAYER PROMPT

"Thank God for making you part of His family. Ask Him to expose prejudice, pride, or indifference and help you welcome people into the church."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Connect with someone in student ministry outside your usual circle. Learn something about their life, include them in a conversation and pray for them during the week.

05 HEART OF WORSHIP
[TBD]

PASSAGE **Revelation 13:1-18; Daniel 3:13-18**

KEY TAKEAWAY

A heart of worship remains loyal to Jesus when following Him comes at a cost.

CALL TO ACTION

[TBD]

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Where are you tempted to compromise your convictions?
2. Is your obedience dependent on God giving you the outcome you want?
3. Are you modeling a faith that remains steady when following Jesus is costly?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Revelation 13. How do the beasts use power, deception, and consequences to demand worship and allegiance?
2. What does Revelation 13:10 call God's people to do? Read Daniel 3:13-18. How do Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego demonstrate that response?

APPLICABLE

1. Where do you feel pressure to compromise your loyalty to Jesus to fit in or avoid losing something?
2. [TBD]

PRAYER PROMPT

"Name the pressures out loud that make obedience difficult. Ask God for discernment, courage, and endurance. Pray for a faith that trusts Him even when the outcome is uncertain."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Identify one situation where you feel pressure to compromise. Decide what a faithful response would look like.

06 HEART OF WORSHIP
[TBD]

PASSAGE **Revelation 22:7-21; Titus 2:11-14**

KEY TAKEAWAY

A heart of worship responds to Jesus with obedience and hope while waiting for His return.

CALL TO ACTION

[TBD]

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Does the promise of Jesus' return shape how you live today?
2. Where have you been delaying something you know Jesus is calling you to do?
3. How is God's grace actively changing your desires, habits, and priorities?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Revelation 22:7-21. What repeated promises and commands show how Jesus wants His people to respond?
2. According to Titus 2:11-14, what does God's grace teach us, and what hope are we waiting for?
3. How do these passages connect expectation of Jesus' return with worship?

APPLICABLE

1. If the promise of Jesus' return shaped your priorities, what would change about your week?
2. Who is someone in your life that you want to know the truth of Jesus? How does knowing that Jesus is coming back affect the urgency with which you share the truth with them?

PRAYER PROMPT

"Pray, "Come, Lord Jesus." Bring Him the broken things you long for Him to restore. Ask for His grace to shape your choices and help you live faithfully while you wait."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Choose one act of obedience you have been delaying and take a concrete step this week. Begin each morning by praying, "Jesus, help me live ready for You today."

SERIES THREE

JOHN 3:16

IS IT REALLY THAT SIMPLE? · 3 WEEKS · MSM + HSM TOGETHER

SERIES DATES _____

SERIES OVERVIEW

JOHN 3:16

John 3:16 is one of the most familiar verses in the Bible, but it raises some of the biggest questions about Christianity. If God loves the world, why is there so much suffering? If He sent His Son, how can we know Jesus really is who He claimed to be? And what does it actually mean to believe in Him? In this series, students will explore these questions honestly, using John 3:16 as the foundation for conversations about God's love, the identity of Jesus, and the meaning of saving faith. The goal isn't to pretend every question has an easy answer, but to help students understand the gospel more deeply and build a thoughtful, confident faith in Jesus.

Series goal: Students will learn to engage honestly with difficult questions about Christianity, understand the biblical foundations of their faith, and grow in confidence that Jesus is who He says He is.

SERIES OUTLINE

WEEK 1	**God Loves the World**	John 11:1-44; Romans 8:18-25
WEEK 2	**He Sent His Son**	John 3:16-18; 1 Corinthians 15:3-8
WEEK 3	**Believe in Him**	John 3:16-18; Ephesians 2:1-10

04 Get visual. A big sticky pad and a few markers pull everyone in—drawing or writing answers out makes the points stick. #leadertip

01 JOHN 3:16
GOD LOVES THE WORLD

PASSAGE **John 11:1-44; Romans 8:18-25**

KEY TAKEAWAY

God doesn't promise a life without suffering, but He meets us in our pain and promises that suffering won't have the final word.

CALL TO ACTION

Bring your honest questions and pain to God, and choose to walk alongside someone who is hurting rather than offering easy answers.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. When you hear the phrase "God loves the world," what does that make you think or feel?
2. Have you ever experienced something that made you question God's goodness or wonder why He would allow suffering? What questions did it raise for you?

BIBLICAL

1. Read John 11:1-44.
   - What words, ideas, or phrases stick out to you from these verses?
   - What questions do you have about these verses?
2. Reread John 11:32-36. What does this teach us about how Jesus responds to human pain?
3. Read Romans 8:18-25. Paul acknowledges that creation groans and that we experience suffering while waiting for redemption. What does this passage teach us about the brokenness of our world and the hope Christians have for the future?

APPLICABLE

1. Is there a painful experience or unanswered question that makes it difficult for you to trust God? What would it look like to bring that honestly to Him?
2. How can you respond when a friend is suffering or questioning God's goodness without minimizing their pain or pretending to have every answer?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, I don't always understand why suffering happens or why You allow painful things in our world. Help me bring my honest questions to You. Remind me of Your character, meet me in my pain, and help me be present with others who are hurting. Give me hope in the promise that You will ultimately make all things new."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Take 10 minutes this week to write down an honest question you have about suffering or God's goodness. Read John 11 or Romans 8 again, noting what the passage teaches you about God and what questions remain. If the question is weighing on you, bring it to a trusted leader or mature Christian.

JOHN 3:16

02 HE SENT HIS SON

PASSAGE **John 3:16-18; 1 Corinthians 15:3-8**

KEY TAKEAWAY

God proved His love by sending His Son, and the resurrection is how we know Jesus is who He claimed to be.

CALL TO ACTION

Take one question you have about Jesus or His resurrection and investigate it rather than avoiding it.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. John 3:16 says God gave His one and only Son. Why do you think God's plan centered on sending a person rather than just sending a message?
2. What evidence or information would you want to examine before believing that someone had actually risen from the dead?

BIBLICAL

1. Read John 3:16-18.
   - What words, ideas, or phrases stick out to you from these verses?
   - What questions do you have about these verses?
2. Reread John 3:16. Why is it significant that Christianity is built around what God has done by sending His Son, rather than simply giving people advice about how to live?
3. Read 1 Corinthians 15:3-8. Paul describes Jesus' death, burial, resurrection, and appearances to witnesses.
   - What claims does Paul make about what happened to Jesus?
   - Why do you think the resurrection was so important to the message he preached?

APPLICABLE

1. What question about Jesus, the Bible's reliability, or the resurrection would you most like to have answered? Why is that question important to you?
2. How can you investigate questions about Christianity with both intellectual honesty and an openness to what the evidence may show?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, thank You for showing Your love by sending Jesus. Help me understand who He is and why His resurrection matters. Give me courage to ask honest questions, wisdom to examine the evidence, and humility as I continue to learn. Help me build my faith on what is true."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Write down one question you have about the historical Jesus or His resurrection. Investigate it using the passages from this week and a trustworthy resource on Christian history or apologetics. Record one thing you learned and one question you still have.

03 JOHN 3:16
BELIEVE IN HIM

PASSAGE **John 3:16-18; Ephesians 2:1-10**

KEY TAKEAWAY

We receive eternal life by God's grace through faith in Jesus, and genuine faith begins to shape how we live.

CALL TO ACTION

Examine what you're trusting in for salvation. Put your confidence in Jesus rather than _____.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. When you hear the phrase "believe in Jesus," what do you think it means? How would you explain it to a friend?
2. Have you ever wondered whether you're really a Christian or worried that you've messed up too much for God to accept you? What makes questions about salvation difficult to work through?

BIBLICAL

1. Read John 3:16-18.
   - What words, ideas, or phrases stick out to you from these verses?
   - What questions do you have about these verses?
2. Reread John 3:16. What do you think it means to believe in Jesus rather than simply believe that He existed? What is the difference between knowing facts about Jesus and personally trusting Him?
3. Read Ephesians 2:1-10. According to Paul, what has God done for us, and how do we receive salvation?

APPLICABLE

1. When you think about your relationship with God, are you more likely to trust what Jesus has done for you or judge your standing with God by how well you've behaved? What do these passages invite you to reconsider?
2. If a friend asked you, "How can I know if I'm actually saved," how would you use John 3:16 and the other passages to help them understand grace, faith, and assurance?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, thank You for loving me and sending Jesus so that I can have eternal life. Help me understand what it means to trust in Him. Keep me from trying to earn Your love through my performance, and help me find confidence in Your promises. Grow my faith so that the way I live reflects the trust I place in You."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Read John 3:16-18 and 1 John 5:11-13 again this week. Write down what these passages teach you about believing in Jesus and having eternal life. If you have questions or doubts about your salvation, bring them to a trusted Christian leader and work through them together.

SERIES FOUR

OPEN

A CONVERSATION ON MENTAL HEALTH · 2 WEEKS

SERIES DATES

SERIES OVERVIEW

OPEN

Does God actually hear me? Is He even real? If He is real, why does it seem like everyone I know is struggling? The mental health conversation is everywhere today—sometimes, it seems like all anyone is ever talking about.

It's easy to talk about mental health, but it's hard to be open about mental health and how it affects us. In this series, we'll search God's Word to find some people who open up about their struggles with anxiety, depression, doubt, and fear. The book of Psalms is full of people who were really, really honest about what they were going through. Each week, we'll use their honesty to challenge ourselves into opening up the conversation about the questions we actually have about God, the emotions we struggle with, and the hope we find when we bring things into the light.

Series goal: Students will engage conversations about how to look to God when things are hard and how to bring hard things into the light.

SERIES OUTLINE

WEEK 1	**Anxiety & Depression**	Psalm 77
WEEK 2	**Doubt & Fear**	Psalm 13:1-4; Psalm 27:13-14

05 Know your Stoplight. Conversations about mental health can move from green to yellow or red fast —review the Stoplight Guide on page 2 before group. #leadertip

01 OPEN
ANXIETY & DEPRESSION

PASSAGE **Psalm 77**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Intentionally remembering what God has done is the best way to push back the darkness of our circumstance.

CALL TO ACTION

Be open about when things are hard and keep remembering the great things God can do.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. What's your ultimate "I had a bad day and want to feel better" routine? Do you have a favorite show to watch, activity to do, friend to call?
2. Anxiety and depression are big topics of conversation these days. When you hear these words, what comes to mind for you?
3. Have you ever had an emotion or tough thought that you felt you couldn't be honest about? What made it hard to share those?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Psalm 77:4-9.
   - — What parts of this scripture can you relate to? Have you ever felt or prayed something like this?
   - — Why do you think a scripture like this might be included in the Bible?
2. Now read Psalm 77:10-15.
   - — What changed?
   - — What things is the author remembering about God?

APPLICABLE

1. Do you think knowing truth about God can actually affect us when we feel anxious or depressed? Why or why not?
2. How can we be grateful for what God has done, but also honest when things are really hard?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, you've done great things—help me remember the great things you've done for me."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

This week, write down something you are grateful for every day. Spend time giving thanks to God for that thing.

02 OPEN
DOUBT & FEAR

PASSAGE **Psalm 13:1-4; Psalm 27:13-14**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Fears and doubts don't disqualify us from faith—they invite us to open our hearts more fully to God and others.

CALL TO ACTION

Be honest about your doubt and fear with God and with your community.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. When you're figuring something out, are you more likely to ask for help or try to figure it out on your own first?
2. Have you ever had thoughts or questions about religion that you felt like you couldn't say out loud?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Psalm 13:1-4.
   - What emotion does this sound like to you?
   - Have you ever wondered if God sees you or hears you?
2. Now read Psalm 27:13-14.
   - What do you think they mean by "be brave and courageous, and wait for the Lord"?

APPLICABLE

1. The writers of these passages are really honest. What's something about faith that you need to be really honest about?
2. When questions or fear about faith come up, what can we do to help encourage each other to "wait for the Lord"?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, I don't have all the answers. Help me be brave and courageous and wait for you, even when it's hard."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

This week, be brave and courageous. Share a fear or doubt you've been keeping to yourself with a trusted leader or friend.

SERIES FIVE

PORN AGAIN?

INTERNAL TRANSFORMATION + BEHAVIOR MODIFICATION = NEW CREATION · 2 WEEKS

SERIES DATES _____

SERIES OVERVIEW

PORN AGAIN?

Jesus tells Nicodemus in John 3 that we must be "BORN again," but the reality is we live in a time where the most defining reality is not being born again, but falling into porn again and again. We want to see this generation break free from strongholds, walk in freedom, and see the power Jesus has to make them into a brand new creation.

Our society is pornified. Things that were obscene years ago are just normal nowadays, and the more saturated our culture is becoming with pornography, the more it's becoming a generational stronghold. The days of just needing to have a "boys talk" don't exist anymore. One of the fastest growing demographics among new pornography users is girls age 8-14. So we want to have an honest conversation about pornography and talk about it from a Biblical worldview and Christian perspective. We know students are going to hear about it at some point, and we want them to hear what God has to say about it, not just a culture that is complacent at best but celebrating it at its worst.

If a generation is going to be freed from pornography and its influence on their life, two things need to coexist together. These are not opposing camps, but each is an essential piece to holistic change. Here's the equation: INTERNAL TRANSFORMATION + BEHAVIOR MODIFICATION = NEW CREATION.

The church struggles to bring these two together. Legalists tell people to simply "Stop It." The belief is: change their behavior and it will change their addictive habits. The truth: ask any individual who tried that and they'll tell you it was only half the battle. The challenge is that our thoughts, desires, and soul aren't being transformed.

Then there are "grace-filled" churches. They recognize we can't change our way into transformation, but often fall into a trap of merely preaching a passive grace with no real practical steps to fight the addiction. Our church loves students too much to leave them in forgiveness to fend for themselves. We long for grace to be backed up by the hard truths, alongside leaders willing to stand in the gap. This is where transformation begins.

SERIES OUTLINE

WEEK 1	**Be Transformed**	Romans 12:1-2; Psalm 51:10
WEEK 2	**Do Not Conform**	Romans 12:2; Psalm 51:10

06 Lead with grace and truth. Students who struggle here often carry shame; your calm, unshocked response tells them it's safe to bring it into the light. #leadertip

01 PORN AGAIN? BE TRANSFORMED

PASSAGE **Romans 12:1-2; Psalm 51:10**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Only the Creator can change the created. All I have to do is ask.

CALL TO ACTION

What things do I need to ask God to do to keep me from falling into porn again?

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. If you could only ask for help from one person you already know for the rest of this year, who would you choose and why would you choose them?
2. When was a time in your life that you realized you couldn't do something on your own? Was it easy or hard to ask for help?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Romans 12:2 again as a group.
   - What words or phrases stand out to you? What questions do you have about this passage?
   - Who is the only one who can truly transform us?
   - How does Romans 12:2 say that transformation takes place?
2. Read Psalm 51:10 again.
   - Who is David asking to do these two things?
   - What do you think happens if we try to do the work of changing our thinking, cleansing our desires, and aligning our spirits?

APPLICABLE

1. What happens in our fight against any sin, especially with pornography, if we don't ask God to do an inner transformation first?

> **PRAYER PROMPT**
>
> *"God, today would you change my thinking, purify my desires, and give me a loyal spirit so that I can be who you made me to be."*

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Write this prayer down to take with you. Each day this week, pray this prayer and make it your own along the way. See what begins to change as you ask God to do what only He can do.

02 PORN AGAIN?
DO NOT CONFORM

PASSAGE **Romans 12:2; Psalm 51:10**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Old habits break when new and better ones are formed.

CALL TO ACTION

[TBD]

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. What is an example from your life where it was easy to just go along with what everyone else around you was doing?
2. What are some practical things that you've been able to do to help you resist peer pressure?
3. What is the difference between passive and active verbs?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Romans 12:2.
   - What is the first command or active verb that is given to us to do?
2. What does it mean to "copy the behavior and customs" of something? What are some behaviors and customs of "this world"?

APPLICABLE

1. If our command is to NOT live like this world, when it comes to sexual sin like pornography, what would it mean to NOT be like the rest of the world? Give some practical examples.
2. Read James 5:16. What does it suggest we do with sin? (Confess and ask for help.)
3. We want every student to have a battle plan to fight temptation, but a battle plan without battle buddies is insufficient. Who are the people in your life that you can invite to know what your battle plan looks like?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, today would you change my thinking, purify my desiring, and give me a loyal spirit so that I can be who you made me to be."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Complete your personal battle plan and share it with your parents, a friend, and a small group leader. What will you give up, and what will you replace it with instead?

SERIES SIX

FUELED

A STUDY OF MARK 6 · 3 WEEKS

SERIES DATES _____

SERIES OVERVIEW

FUELED

What makes you...you? What drives the way you live, the choices you make, and the way you treat the people around you? As believers in Jesus, we want the things that are true about Jesus to be true about us.

Throughout the Gospel of Mark, we see that Jesus was fueled by His identity as the beloved Son of God. Before the miracles, the teaching, or the crowds, Jesus knew who He was and whose He was. We also see him moved to action by compassion, putting aside personal comfort for the sake of others. And even in the hardest moments of life, we see Jesus made space for prayer, seeking His Father and aligning His desires with God's will.

These weren't just things Jesus believed; they were the things that fueled him on his journey from heaven to the cross and back again. In this series, we'll study three driving forces that defined Jesus' life: being a dearly loved Son, being moved with compassion for others, and being aligned with God's will through prayer.

Through moments from Jesus' life in Mark, we'll discover that following Jesus isn't just about knowing the story of his life, it's about allowing what fueled Him to be the thing that fuels us.

SERIES OUTLINE

WEEK 1	**Fueled by Identity**	Mark 1:9-11
WEEK 2	**Fueled by Compassion**	Mark 6:30-44
WEEK 3	**Fueled by Prayer**	Mark 14:35-40

07 Involve every student. Ask a question for everyone to answer. Don't rush to fill the silence or answer the question. Ask questions of their questions. #leadertip

01 FUELED
FUELED BY IDENTITY

PASSAGE **Mark 1:9-11**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Knowing God loves us should be the truest thing about us—His love moves us to change how we live.

CALL TO ACTION

Let God's love define you.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. What's in your "starter pack"? Share three to five things that would help someone get to know you if they met you for the first time.
2. What do you think makes us who we are? Is it who we spend time with, what we think, or something else?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Mark 1:9-11.
   - What stands out to you about these verses?
   - What does this passage say about Jesus' identity?
2. Jesus is God's "dearly loved son," but he still faced temptation and hard times. How do you think knowing his identity affected his actions?

APPLICABLE

1. What would it be like for you to hear that you are dearly loved by God, or that you bring God joy? Is that easy or hard to believe?
2. Imagine you woke up tomorrow and you 100% believed that God's love was the truest thing about you. How would that change your day? What things would you stop doing or start doing based on your new identity?

> **PRAYER PROMPT**
>
> *"God, help me believe your love is for me. Sometimes I feel like _____ is the truest thing about me. Help me believe that your love defines me."*

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Write this statement somewhere you'll see it and say it out loud every day this week. See how long you can keep your streak. Bonus points: challenge your small group to send a voice memo in the chat each day! "I am dearly loved by God. He has a good plan for my life, and He deeply cares about how I live."

02 FUELED BY COMPASSION

FUELED

PASSAGE **Mark 6:30-44**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Compassion moves us to serve others even when it's uncomfortable.

CALL TO ACTION

Do something for someone that meets a need, even if it's outside your comfort zone.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. What's the nicest thing someone has ever done for you?
2. Think about our community. What do you think are some of the biggest needs people have?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Mark 6:30-44.
   - What stands out to you from these verses?
   - Before Jesus had compassion for the people, what were he and the disciples going to search for?
2. Why do you think Jesus set aside what he wanted and chose to teach and feed the people?
3. How does knowing Jesus was moved by compassion change how we serve other people?

APPLICABLE

1. What kinds of things keep you from caring for other people? Do you think it's easy or hard to do something for someone if you know you won't get something in return?
2. What's a kind of person or situation that "moves you to compassion"? What's a way you might be able to act on your compassion this week?

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, I want my heart to be like yours. Grow my compassion for people and open my eyes to who you would want to serve."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

Consider your neighborhood, community, family, or school. What needs do you notice? Consider if there's something you could do for someone else without expecting to get anything in return.

03 FUELED
FUELED BY PRAYER

PASSAGE **Mark 14:35-40**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Prayer fuels us to do God's will, even when it costs us something.

CALL TO ACTION

Pray! Ask God for what you need and practice submitting to his plan.

LEADER NOTES

QUESTIONS

PERSONAL

1. Have you ever asked for something you ended up getting? Have you ever asked for something you didn't end up getting?
2. When it comes to prayer, how would you describe it? What is it, and why do Christians do it?

BIBLICAL

1. Read Mark 14:35-36.
   - — What stands out to you about this passage?
   - — What is Jesus asking?
2. Now read Mark 14:37-40.
   - — Why does Jesus say his friends should pray?
   - — Jesus prays and then follows through with God's plan. The disciples don't pray and end up deserting Jesus when he needs them. Why do you think that happened?

APPLICABLE

1. Have you ever cried out to God about something difficult like Jesus did? What happened?
2. This passage helps us see that through prayer we can ask God for what we need, but prayer also helps line up our will with God's will. Is it easy or hard to want the things that God wants? If you were to pray a prayer like Jesus prayed, what would it sound like? (Hint: "God, I need _____, but not my will, but yours be done.")

PRAYER PROMPT

"God, I don't always understand what you want. Help me line my heart up with yours."

PERSONAL CHALLENGE

This week, choose a need, a person, or a situation in your life and spend time asking God to help you do what He would do when it comes to that thing.

FOR YOUR GROUP

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FOR YOUR GROUP

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SPACE TO DRAW

SKETCH

SKETCH

Southeast
Students